

SPECIAL FORCES WEAPONS

Special Forces units are sometimes required to deploy specialist weapons. Rock-solid reliability is a precondition for any such selection; a high-level of firepower makes small arms such as the Franchi shotgun and the Glock pistol popular choices. At other times stealth weapons are needed. But the most interesting recent development has been the introduction of the Personal Defense Weapon (PDW), such as the FN P90. This dispenses with the old Parabellum submachine-gun cartridge in favour of a smaller but more powerful round that can penetrate body armour.



Recoil spring housing

▲ FN BROWNING HP35
Date 1935
Origin Belgium
Weight 1kg (2¼lb)
Barrel 11.8cm (4¾in)
Calibre 9 × 19mm

John Moses Browning's last design, this high-capacity weapon set the standard for modern self-loading pistols, and has been used by British, German, and Canadian forces.



► HECKLER & KOCH MP5
Date 1966
Origin Germany
Weight 3.1kg (6¾lb)
Barrel 22.5cm (8¾in)
Calibre 9 × 19mm

The most important and widely used submachine-gun of the modern period, combining accuracy and reliability, the MP5 has three rates of fire: single-shot, three-round burst, and automatic.



▲ INGRAM M10
Date 1970
Origin US
Weight 3.4kg (7½lb)
Barrel 11.4cm (4½in)
Calibre 0.45in

With a cyclical rate of fire of well over 1,000 rounds per minute, the Ingram M10 can empty its magazine in just over a second. The suppressor is essential to retain control over firing.



▲ FRANCHI SPAS 12
Date 1978
Origin Italy
Weight 4.4kg (9¾lb)
Barrel 54.5cm (21½in)
Calibre 12-bore

Developed as a close-combat weapon for both police and military, the Special Purpose Automatic Shotgun (SPAS) is gas-operated (with an optional pump mode) and holds eight rounds in an under-barrel tubular magazine.

Weapon can be fitted with a 15- or 30-round magazine

Retractable butt stock

Combined pistol grip and magazine holding 32 rounds

Magazine release catch

Optical sight

Muzzle